

Wildfires and Air Quality

Hundreds of wildfires burning across Canada caused air quality warnings to be issued in various parts of the United States as the mix of gas and particles from the smoke traveled south. According to the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention (CDC), wildfire smoke is dangerous for all people, but those with asthma, chronic obstructive lung disease, or heart disease, as well as pregnant women, and children are at increased risk.¹ The United States Environmental Protection Agency (EPA) notes that even if the fire is far away, the greatest risk is from microscopic particles that can enter your respiratory system, exacerbating current health conditions.² A study of climate change indicators by the EPA estimates that the frequency and severity of wildfires in the United States is increasing, due in part to changes in temperature and increased periods of drought, as examples.³

WHAT THE IMPACT WILL BE

Protecting both employee health and patient populations from wildfire smoke may involve mobilizing available federal, state, local, and hospital services and understanding air quality readings in your area. A few key points include:

- Consider a multidisciplinary team of clinical and non-clinical experts to discuss emergency management plans during crisis and planning for long term solutions. Toolkits exist to help with development of these efforts. One example discussing health sector resiliency to climate change, can be found [here](#).⁴
- Hospitals may want to engage experts including but not limited to, environmental services and facilities management to assess/discuss current air quality expectations and future needs.
- Engaging local departments of public health may help to highlight state regulations or support. For example, the California Department of Public Health provides information on emergency preparedness on wildfires and safety, found [here](#).⁵
- The CDC provides detailed information on Air Quality Resources for Professionals, including links to specific training for healthcare professionals found [here](#).⁶

For additional information, review the CDC, EPA, and AirNow websites listed below.

OTHER RESOURCES

- CDC: Protect Yourself from Wildfire Smoke, [found here](#).¹
- EPA: Wildfires and Indoor Air Quality, [found here](#).⁷
- EPA: Wildfires, [found here](#).²
- AirNow: Wildfires, [found here](#).⁸

REFERENCES

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